

Gen AI

A CEO's handbook to avoiding disruption



What Gen AI means for CEOs

Gen AI is moving faster than anything we have seen before. The pace of innovation, adoption, and hype is unprecedented, and every week brings new breakthroughs, new products, and new promises.

Yet the business impact remains limited. Although a majority of companies now indicate they're running experiments with Gen AI across functions, many initiatives stall in pilots or fail to scale across the organization.

At SparkOptimus, we have seen these dynamics before. After fifteen years of guiding companies in digital transformations, we have built a deep understanding of what it takes to capture real business value and drive change in the face of disruption. The digital revolution reshaped entire industries, and many of the same lessons and principles apply now with Gen AI.

This booklet is written to share our lessons with you; to understand the impact of Gen AI, to share how to capture direct productivity gains, but also to prepare for the bigger disruption still to come.



Alexandra Jankovich
Managing Partner &
Co-Founder SparkOptimus



Matti van Engelen
Associate partner &
AI Lead

What Gen AI means for CEOs

Gen AI is moving faster than anything we have seen before. The pace of innovation, adoption, and hype is unprecedented, and every week brings new breakthroughs, new products, and new promises.

Yet the business impact remains limited. Although a majority of companies now indicate they're running experiments with Gen AI across functions, many initiatives stall in pilots or fail to scale across the organization.

At SparkOptimus, we have seen these dynamics before. After fifteen years of guiding companies in digital transformations, we have built a deep understanding of what it takes to capture real business value and drive change in the face of disruption. The digital revolution reshaped entire industries, and many of the same lessons and principles apply now with Gen AI.

This booklet is written to share our lessons with you; to understand the impact of Gen AI, to share how to capture direct productivity gains, but also to prepare for the bigger disruption still to come.



Alexandra Jankovich
Managing Partner &
Co-Founder SparkOptimus



Matti van Engelen
Associate partner &
AI Lead

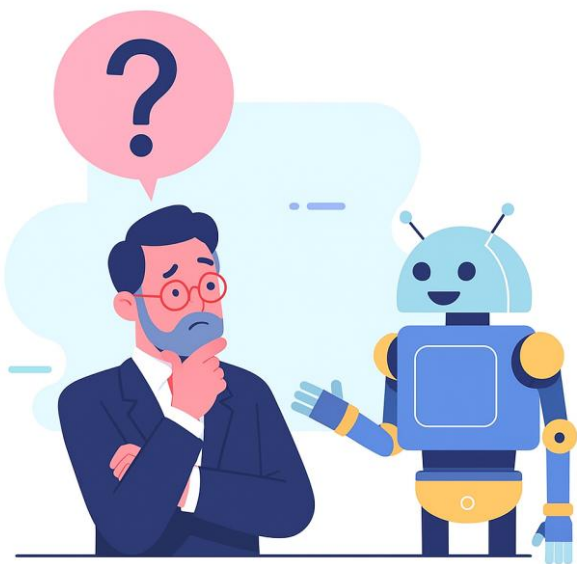
1 Gen AI 101: What makes it special

2 Today: Productivity

3 Tomorrow: disruption

4 How to avoid being disrupted

Contents



1

Gen AI 101: What makes it special



Prompt:
 "A classic diner restaurant called
 Joe's in large neon letters"

Huge productivity gains lie ahead

Gen AI is already showing impact in frontrunner functions, with recent SparkOptimus benchmarks showing best-in-class efficiency gains of 70% in customer service, 50% in marketing, and 40% in software development, with other functions following closely behind. All this only 3 years after the launch of ChatGPT; no other technology has realized impact this quickly.

This promise to skyrocket productivity causes a modern gold rush, leading to unprecedented investments & valuations.

Why is this different?

Gen AI is improving at breakneck speed. In just three years, unrecognizable pixels have given way to images indistinguishable from reality, and the same acceleration is happening across text, voice, and video. The race toward limitless white-collar productivity has only just begun.



It's remarkable how text-based Gen AI models like ChatGPT, trained on nothing more than vast amounts of text, have developed a genuine understanding of language, grasping meaning, nuance, and context. But the next big breakthrough will probably come from video models. Trained only on raw footage, they're not simply generating frames, but they're also beginning to understand the world itself; learning physics, not just from text, but from the real world.

Blue-collar work will not be left alone

As these models learn to interact with the real world, general-purpose robots will come within reach. No longer limited to single, repetitive tasks, these machines can interpret their surroundings, use reasoning, and execute complex

Why is this different?

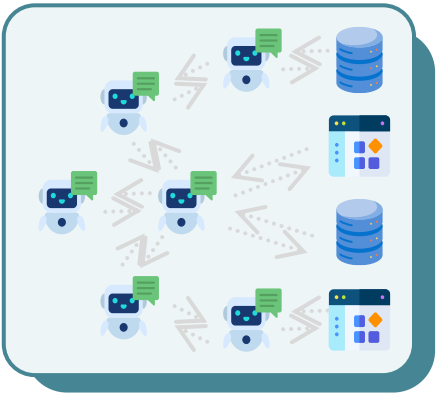
Unlike earlier automation, this is not about single-task, preprogrammed machines. New multimodal and video-trained models can interpret their environment, reason about what to do next, and execute multi-step instructions. This shifts blue-collar automation from narrow, scripted workflows to generalist capability that can handle variability, novelty, and real-world complexity.

the now
the day

From



To



Agentic AI enables human-like collaboration

The rise of agentic AI means Gen AI systems can increasingly operate much like human teams: they coordinate toward shared goals, make decisions, discuss next steps, and take actions autonomously.

While this may sound complex, agents are essentially autonomous Gen AI models that behave as “digital colleagues”. Each agent typically specializes in a specific task

Why is this different?

Early Gen AI models were hard to optimize for complex, multi-step tasks, since there is only so much a single Gen AI model can do. This meant Gen AI impact was limited to automation of isolated, simple tasks

Client example

One of our FMCG clients uses a series of Gen AI agents to develop marketing campaign materials, cutting campaign creation time by up to 50%. Within minutes, it can brief other agents to analyze the target audience, create ad content, design visuals, set up the campaign in the marketing tools, and report on performance



A single Gen AI model can perform millions of tasks

A single Gen AI model, such as ChatGPT, Gemini, or Copilot, can perform millions of tasks. These are not just routine jobs; they include creative and cognitive work once thought to be uniquely human: writing marketing copy, generating code, designing presentations, drafting legal documents, or simulating customer conversations.

Unlike earlier technologies that merely analyzed data, Gen AI creates. It turns simple, natural input (text, voice, image, or video) into complex and high-quality output. This means anyone can access its power, using a single model for an almost limitless range of tasks. At clients, we already see a clear pattern emerging implementing Gen AI often comes

Why is this different?

Before Gen AI, analytical AI needed a tailored model for every single application. For example, a bank that wanted to detect fraud, assess credit risk, and rank most common customer complaints needed three separate AI models, each trained on its own data and maintained by teams of data scientists. With Gen AI, one model can do all three applications (and millions more) through easy, human-like input instead of complex code.

[JanPit]

- Less puke green, but you get the idea



Forget the bubble (unless you're an investor)

With the power of Gen AI models & agentic AI, it doesn't matter whether we're in a Gen AI bubble or not, because Gen AI is here to stay.

Yes, there are signs of speculation. Many companies struggle to measure ROI; our benchmarks show only 10% of Gen AI pilots are scaling successfully, and valuations keep rising, with AI frontrunners making circular investments, creating a feedback loop of optimism and capital.

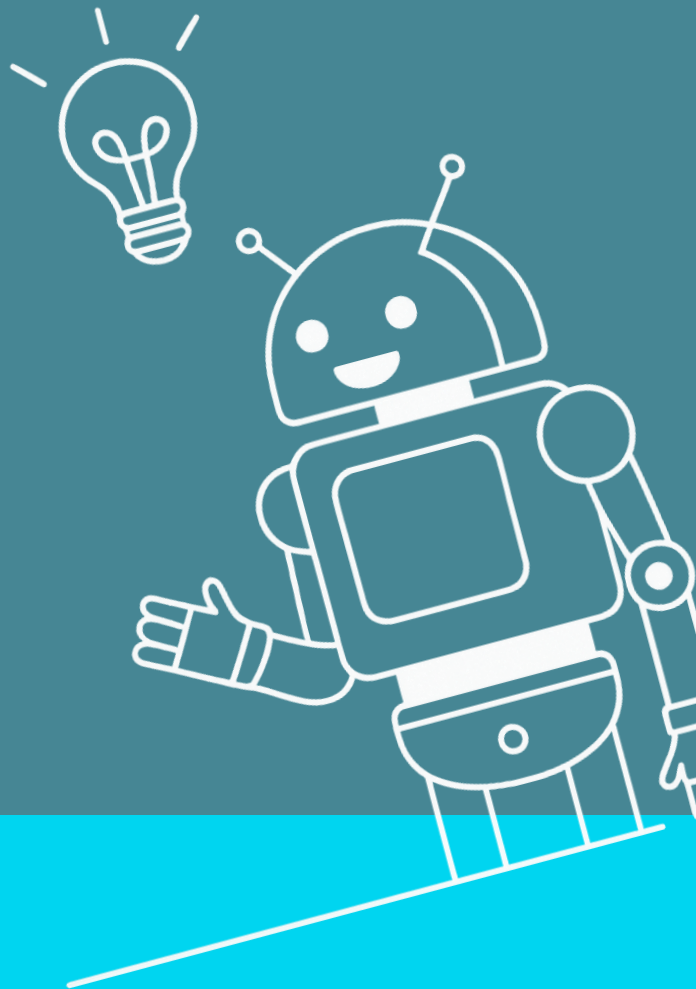
However, we've seen this story play out before. In the 19th century, railways sparked a massive speculative boom. The bubble eventually burst, but the rail infrastructure that remained transformed economies anyway, by slashing

Why is this different?

It's not; the same dynamics will play out here. Gen AI might be in a bubble, but whether this wave fuels advances in compute power, AI robotics, or something entirely new, the foundations being built today will shape how businesses, and entire industries, operate for decades to come

Key lessons

- Huge productivity gains lie ahead
- Blue collar work will not be left alone
- Agentic AI enables human-like collaboration
- A single Gen AI model can perform millions of tasks
- Forget the bubble (unless you're an investor)

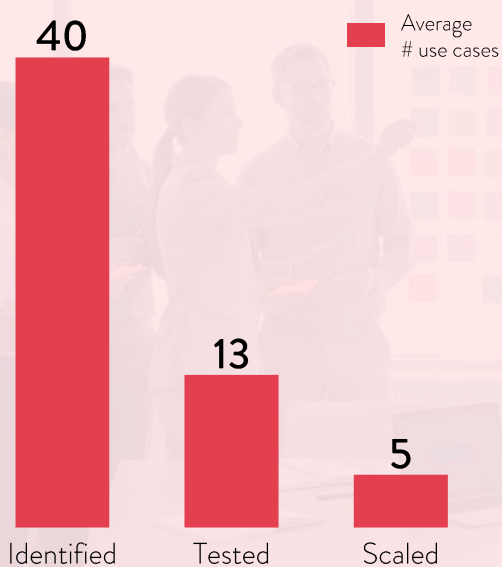




2

Today: Productivity

Only 12% of Gen AI initiatives
are successfully scaled
(SparkOptimus Gen AI benchmark)



Almost every company is now experimenting with Gen AI to boost productivity, typically focused on functionally siloed use cases, such as sales chatbot support, marketing content generation, legal document review, or knowledge bases.

The race is on to stay competitive in this area, and you need to keep up. Front-running industries like technology, media, and insurance are realizing significant efficiency gains and cost reductions, with more on the horizon.

However, impact varies, with our benchmarks showing only 12% of Gen AI initiatives scaling successfully across departments.

You should realize that this lack of impact is rarely a Gen AI

Client example

A client's CRM lacked complete data because sales reps rarely updated it. We built a Gen AI tool that automatically researches and classifies leads, learning from earlier manual examples. The tool saves sales reps around two hours of research time per lead, allowing for more sales visits.



Sectors with FTE-heavy operational functions lead

Deep tech, media, and banking & insurance are emerging as the leaders in Gen AI adoption because their personnel-heavy operational functions offer the fastest and most tangible cost benefits. These sectors rely on large, process-intensive activities such as content production, engineering workflows, customer service, underwriting, and claims processing. Gen AI slots directly into these tasks, automating routine work and reducing manual load rapidly.

The economics are straightforward. Even modest levels of automation in these environments generate significant savings

Client example

A national energy & telecom services provider sought to implement Gen AI in its customer service processes. After identifying relevant use cases, the first pilots saw 15% time savings in CS functions just 6 months after ChatGPT first launched. Now, these time savings have scaled up to 40%.

Most organizations still anchor their early Gen AI efforts in IT teams, innovation hubs, or dedicated “AI labs.” For functional change on new and complex topics, this approach makes sense. These groups bring rare expertise, understand the technical constraints, and can quickly deliver functional efficiency gains in areas where the business has pain points.

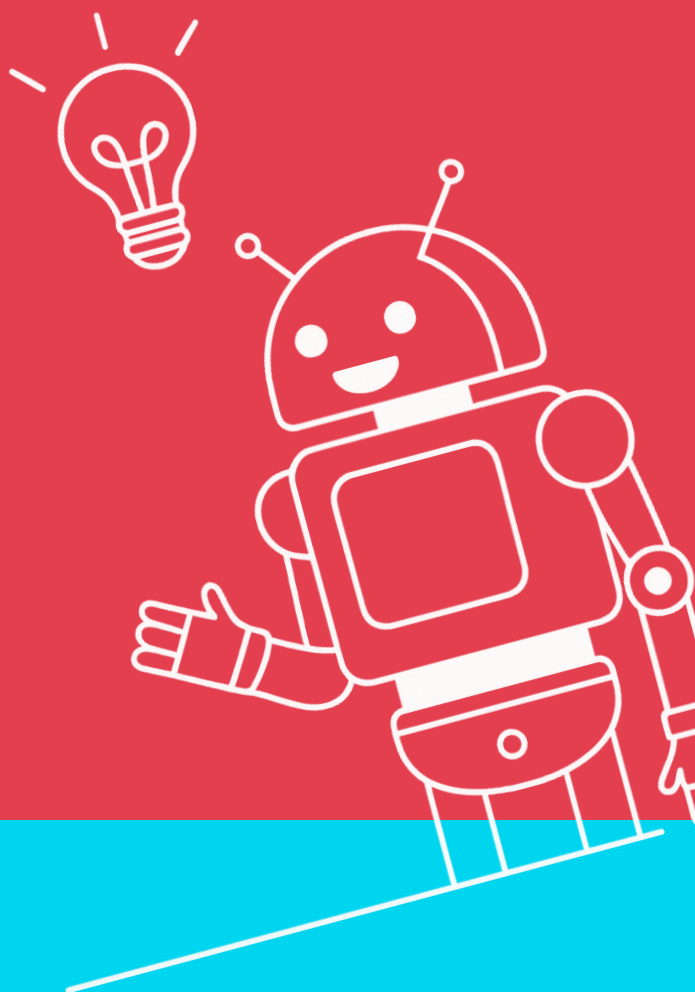
But this setup also has limitations. Expert-driven teams tend to focus on technical challenges or narrow proofs of concept, which rarely scale across the enterprise. Because they operate at a distance from commercial, operational, and customer-facing functions, their impact often remains confined to specific pockets rather than reshaping how the company

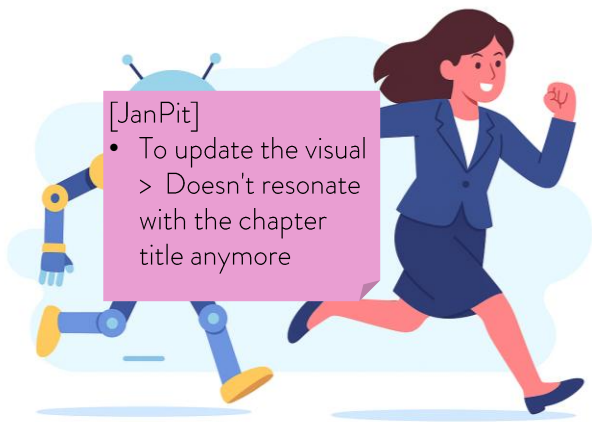
Client example

A €4B utilities company centralized its Gen AI efforts in a single center of expertise. This helped deliver fast, functional gains, including a 30% reduction in maintenance costs, a 40% drop in customer service workload, and a 25% reduction in IT support costs. However, when starting to develop a customer-facing app they quickly realized this approach was too siloed.

Key lessons

- > Productivity is the name of the game (for now)
- > Sectors with FTE-heavy operational functions lead
- > IT and 'AI labs' lead the way





3

Tomorrow: disruption



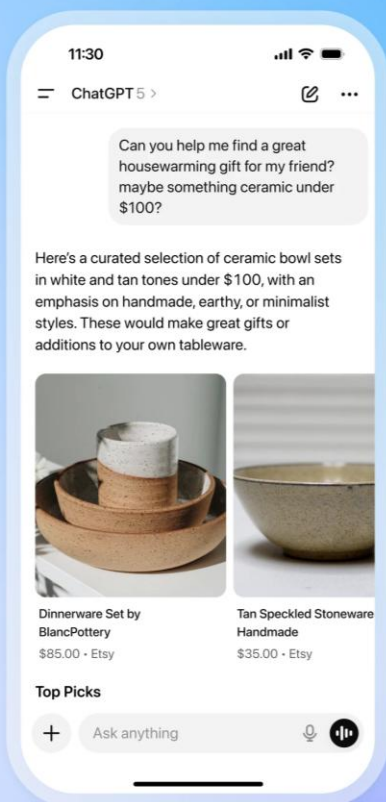
Ultimately, dealing with disruption has never been about cutting costs but about redefining your proposition. Incumbents who are focused on cost-saving alone are overtaken by challengers who fundamentally reimagine how customer needs are met through new technologies and experiences.

You can't cost-save yourself out of disruption

Lessons from digital

In the 2000s, Thomas Cook was the go-to player for booking your holidays, who's desk bound agents held all the information: flights, hotels, and prices, while you had to trust that what they booked matched your needs and budget.

Thomas Cook could have optimized every part of that model: implemented a new ERP system, improved workforce planning, or fine-tuned marketing efficiency: None of it would have prevented disruption by Booking.com, because Booking didn't focus on costs. It reinvented how customer needs were met by using digital to deliver transparency, speed, and control. Suddenly, travelers could see every hotel, compare prices, and read reviews instantly.



Gen AI will change our virtual interface

Gen AI companies are racing to become the new gateway to the internet. This ambition makes sense, because many people already use Gen AI much like they use Google: around half of all ChatGPT interactions are information-seeking.

To capture this interaction, companies like OpenAI and Google are expanding beyond chatbots. They are building full platforms that integrate browsing, advertising, and even instant shopping. ChatGPT, for example, now includes its own browser and check-out flow. Google is following suit, building an ecosystem around Search, Chrome, and Ads.

With over a billion monthly Gen AI chatbot users and growth surpassing that of the early internet, Gen AI is set to rival or even replace classic platforms as the default way people search, learn, and explore – although customers will do it in a fundamentally new way: through speech and human questioning, not keywords.

Lessons from digital

When Google emerged, it offered such an intuitive and customer-focused way to find information that it quickly became the primary gateway to the internet. For brands, not showing up on Google meant losing visibility and losing customers, because if you were not discoverable there, you were effectively invisible.



The race to dominate Gen AI is moving beyond chatbots into the physical realm. Tech giants are building AI-native devices, such as smart glasses, earbuds, and wearables, that will slowly replace or augment our phones. Powered by models like ChatGPT, they give everyone access to a private “AI butler”, which is much more capable than today’s voice assistants. The reason people will shift is that these AI-enabled devices offer a better and faster customer experience compared to phones.

Gen AI will change our physical interface

The rise of new devices and interfaces also opens the next

Lessons from digital

From the introduction of the iPhone in 2007, it took only 5 years before the majority (54%) of the US population owned a smartphone. 2 years later, it was 75%. Technological shifts can happen fast, and companies need to prepare.

Industry example

ABB launched Service Assist in 2023 and expanded it through 2024 as a mobile AR tool that gives field technicians step by step maintenance guidance directly overlaid on real equipment. It combines AR annotations, remote expert support and natural language features to speed up troubleshooting and reduce the need for specialist travel.



“Heads up, Edwin & Anna’s wedding is in 4 weeks on July 28th. **I pulled together 3 outfit ideas that fit your style and the event. Want a quick look?**”

The message is simple: be where your customers are. And this is shifting fast. Customers are already finding information and making decisions through AI agents rather than search engines. As an extreme example: a recent survey of US high schoolers found 20% consider themselves having a romantic relationship with a Gen AI chatbot.

This means optimizing for Gen AI discoverability and agent-driven payments becomes a necessity, instead of Google visibility and search engine advertising.

Be where your customers are and serve them better, faster, easier

Customer needs don’t change, whether it’s a consumer wanting affordable fashion or a farmer striving for efficiency and sustainability. However, Gen AI simply allows companies to meet their needs better, faster, and easier. This isn’t future talk. It’s already happening, and it will redefine how every business serves its customers.

Lessons from digital

Smartphones quickly reshaped customer behavior, with interactions moving to mobile platforms. The consequences for business models were dramatic, and companies that did not optimize their customer experiences for mobile rapidly lost market share. Vakantievelingen.nl, for example, saw sales drop about 30 percent in the early 2010s because its mobile conversion was only a quarter of its desktop site.

Both AI-native entrants and generalists, such as OpenAI or Google, will aggressively compete to capture the customer interface. Adaptive companies may well navigate this shift. However, more traditional businesses will need to think

Own the customer relationship

If you can control the customer relationship, you ultimately control the entire value chain. By owning the primary touchpoint, you can shape customer expectations, set the standards for products and services, and exert significant influence over margins across the ecosystem. This makes the customer interface the most strategic position to hold.

Lessons from digital

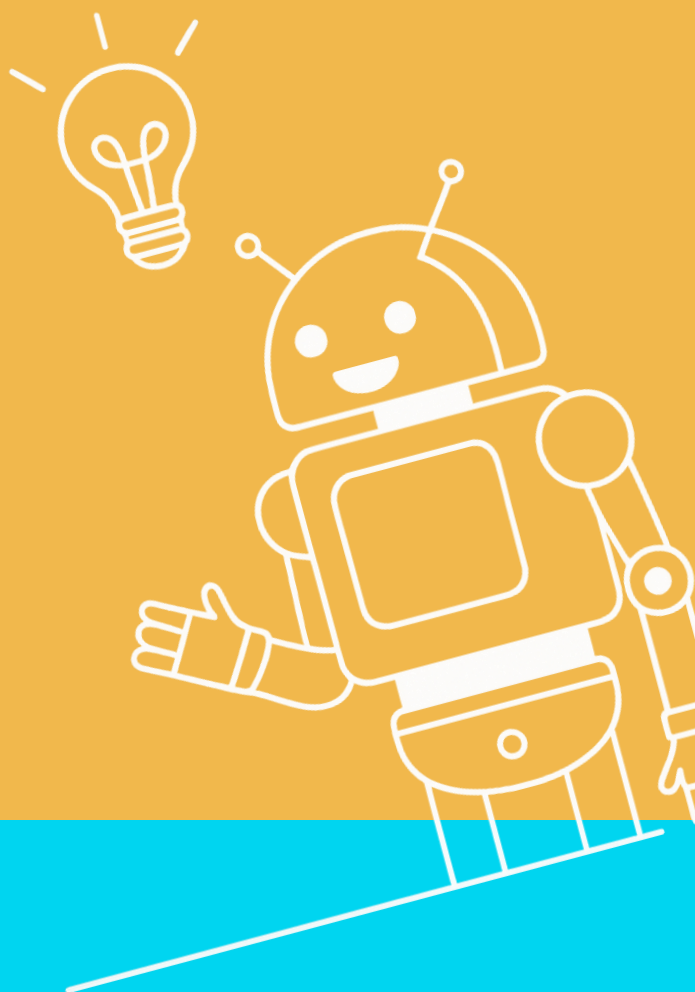
We have seen similar dynamics play out before in the digital space. For example, Google gradually expanded from search into adjacent domains like travel, news, and local services, repositioning itself as the gateway to those industries, meaning that service providers had to adapt to become visible on these new platforms or risk losing customers

Industry example

As B2B customers demanded faster and more digital interactions, many traditional players were slow to respond and risked losing ground to digital entrants. We helped Kramp by building a best-in-class digital B2B platform, sharply improving customer experiences and growing online sales from 0 to 90 percent, effectively strengthening their value chain position.

Key lessons

- > You can't cost-save yourself out of disruption
- > Gen AI will change our virtual interface
- > Gen AI will change our physical interface
- > Be where your customers are and serve them better, faster, easier
- > Own the customer to own the value chain





4

How to avoid being disrupted

Use Gen AI to strengthen existing ambitions

Gen AI should never sit apart from your broader business strategy. It is not a standalone goal but a tool to accelerate the ambitions you already have. Start from your commercial priorities, core KPIs, and long-term vision, and then identify where Gen AI can remove bottlenecks, unlock new value, or help you reach those goals faster and at lower cost.

At the same time, leaders should revisit their strategic vision through the lens of Gen AI's disruptive potential. The technology may reshape customer expectations, shift value pools, or enable entirely new business models. Using Gen AI to

What you can do tomorrow

- › Refine your overall strategy & targets considering Gen AI opportunities & risks
- › Determine where Gen AI is needed to reach your (new) targets
- › Concretize Gen AI use cases strengthening strategy
- › Prioritize use cases on impact (importance to strategy, value creation, customer impact) & feasibility

Start now by leveraging off the shelf Gen AI capabilities

Gen AI lets you start fast by working with powerful off-the-shelf models rather than building complex infrastructure from scratch. Focus is on input data integration, model prompting to generate insights or actions, and output processing to feed data back into your workflows so the business can use it immediately. Because Gen AI models are general purpose and highly capable, you no longer need large teams of data scientists to begin creating value.

This speed has another advantage: early wins quickly build momentum and enthusiasm across the organization, making it easier to scale adoption. It is also how most leading companies

What you can do tomorrow

- › Prioritize high-feasibility (tech, data, organization, way of working, change required) use cases to realize quick wins and build enthusiasm
- › Leverage off-the-shelf Gen AI models for rapid impact, focusing development on data integration
- › Use existing development capabilities, as limited specialized roles are required

Productivity gains are a no-brainer, but as we've seen, they are not where disruption happens. Real disruption occurs when you continuously evolve your customer proposition, serving customers better, faster, and easier.

A big advantage of Gen AI is that you can use the short-term ROI from AI-driven efficiency to fund improvements on your customer proposition and create a lasting competitive edge. A typical spread we see winners use is to spend 70-90% on

Reinvest productivity gains to improve your proposition

What you can do tomorrow

- > Start realizing ROI with high-feasibility use cases
- > Prioritize high-impact use cases most important to overall strategy and proposition
- > Use part of realized ROI to fund more complex Gen AI proposition changes

Put your business in the lead in small teams, and test-and-learn what works

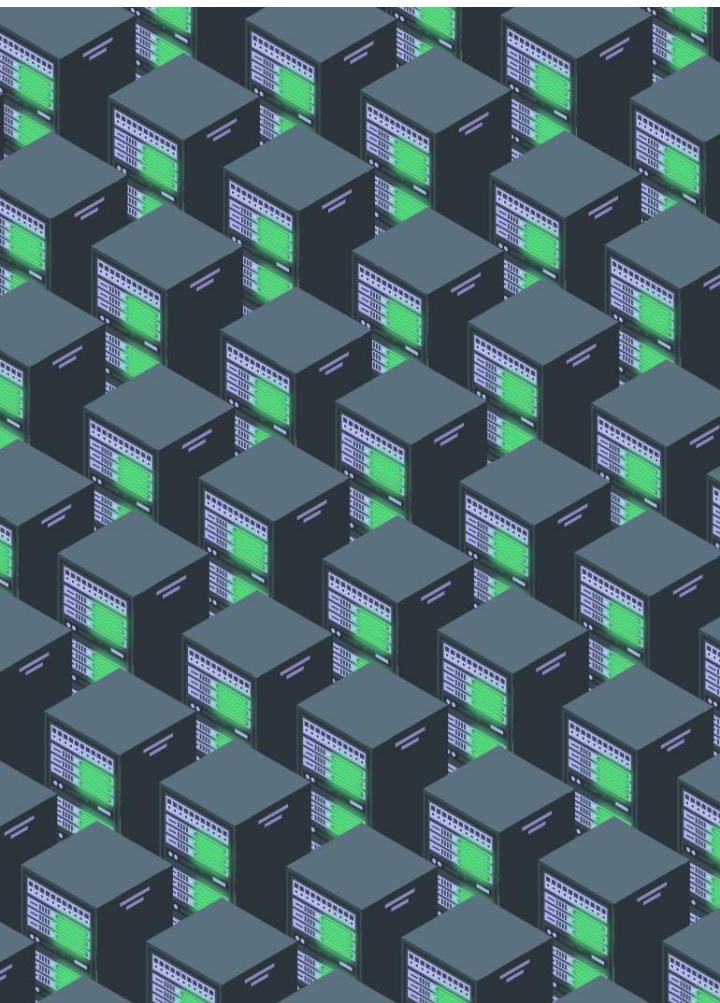
The only way to drive real Gen AI transformation is to put the business, not IT, in the lead, and to do so through customer-oriented end-to-end teams. Traditional AI labs or CoEs can help with productivity, but they are too far removed from customers and too siloed to reinvent the proposition; the scale of change required is simply too big to be driven from a central technical function.

The mandate of these end-to-end teams is to learn fast: continuously testing with real customers, validating what truly creates value, and iterating based on feedback. Fast experimentation helps teams to de-risk ideas early and avoid scaling what does not work. Moreover, the teams should involve all relevant functions early on (including legal and

This

What you can do tomorrow

- › Lead transformational, cross-functional initiatives from the business
- › Focus on real customers in end-to-end teams
- › Test at low tech & low risk to learn what works and what doesn't, before scaling
- › Involve compliance & legal from the start to remove blockers



Get Digital, Data, and Cybersecurity in order (as Gen AI is built on top)

Building agentic AI solutions is only possible when your digital, data, and security foundations are strong. These fundamentals have always been important, especially in today's geopolitical landscape. But with systems that can act autonomously across workflows, they become business-critical. You can build an impressive interface, but without integrated, reliable data underneath, it simply will not work. An agentic AI travel platform, for example, only becomes useful when it can draw on hotel reviews, real-time availability, pricing, and personalized customer insights to act on behalf of a user.

Agentic systems will also require access to sensitive data, tools, and core operational platforms. This means organizations need to decide early what these systems are allowed to access and under which conditions. Clear permissions, controlled

What you can do tomorrow

- › Start fixing/building Digital & Data infrastructure for key use cases
- › Put clear data governance in place for structured and unstructured data
- › Involve cybersecurity & privacy throughout ideation, testing, and scaling of use cases

Lead the change

Since all jobs stand to be reshaped by Gen AI to varying degrees, change management becomes a critical leadership responsibility. Every role will either see tasks automated or redesigned, or will fundamentally change. This means employees will naturally have questions, concerns, and in some cases show resistance. Navigating this shift is not just about rolling out new technology. It is about helping people understand what the change means for them and how they can grow with it.

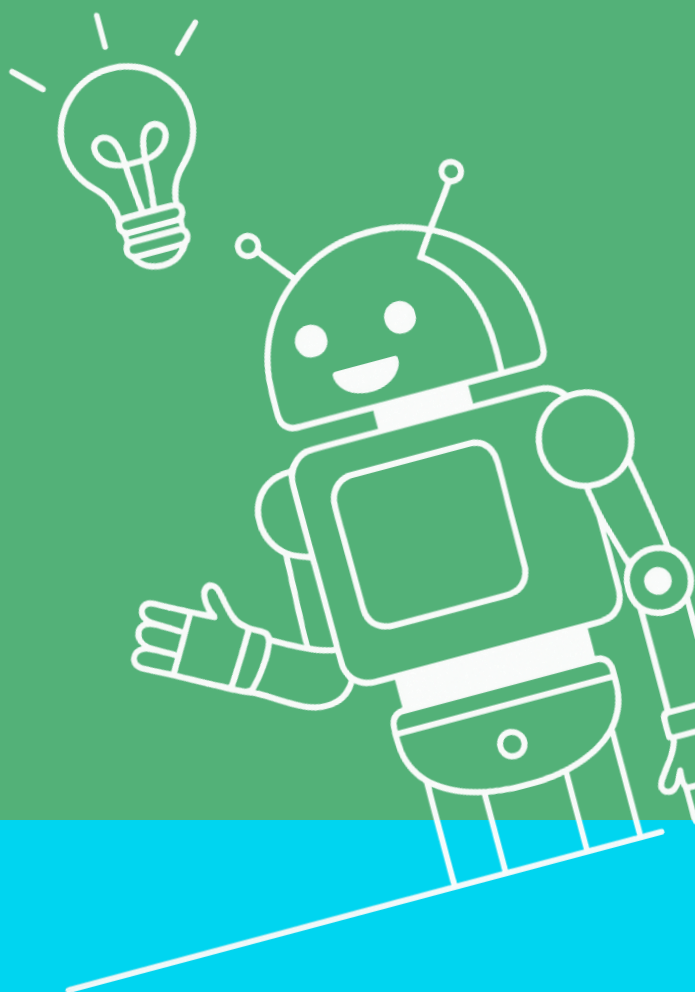
The most successful organizations approach this as a people-first change journey. They actively plan how to reinvest the time freed up by automation, ensuring employees move toward higher-value work rather than feeling displaced. They

What you can do tomorrow

- > Realize jobs will be affected & there will be resistance
- > Proactively determine how to reinvest freed up time
- > Focus on coalition of the willing (early adopters?) first to generate trust & enthusiasm
- > Use early adopters to guide the rest of the organization

Key lessons

- Use Gen AI to strengthen existing ambitions
- Start now by leveraging off-the-shelf Gen AI capabilities
- Reinvest productivity gains to improve your proposition
- Put your business in the lead in small teams, and test-and-learn what works
- Get Digital, Data, and Cybersecurity in order (as Gen AI is built on top)
- Lead the change





There could be doom ahead, or a perfect new world

The future of Gen AI is deeply uncertain.

Autonomous weapons systems could trigger Gen AI arms races between superpowers; mass disinformation lies on the horizon; cyber-attacks will scale, and erosion of trust in institutions could arise. It is clear why some believe we are at the start of a perilous few years.

At the same time, an entirely different future is equally plausible; one where Gen AI unlocks unprecedented progress. We could see a step-change in blue-collar productivity, safer factories, and smarter infrastructure. Gen AI may accelerate the discovery of new medicines, help us tackle climate challenges, and allow us to solve problems that remained out of reach for decades. In this version of the future, AI becomes an engine of broad-based prosperity.

Most likely, we will see elements of both worlds emerge. The outcome will depend on the choices leaders make today: how governments regulate, how companies deploy these tools, and how societies adapt. The uncertainty is real, but so is the opportunity to shape Gen AI toward the future we want.

[MattivanEngelen]
• TBD

SparkOptimus can help create Gen AI value

1

Gen AI education
Supervisory board & board of director masterclasses & education sessions

2

Gen AI Strategy
Develop Gen AI vision and required enablers to create value at scale

3

Gen AI Value Scan
Identify, prioritize, and detail relevant Gen AI use cases in 1 week

4

Gen AI Kickstart
Start value creation while setting up the foundation for scale

5

Gen AI Scaling
Scale successful use cases effectively across your organization

Get in touch!



Alexandra Jankovich
Founder & Managing Partner
a.jankovich@sparkoptimus.com



Tom Voskes
Founder & Managing Partner
t.voskes@sparkoptimus.com



Matti van Engelen
Associate Partner | Practice Lead Data & AI
m.vanengelen@sparkoptimus.com